

Κράτης ὁ Κωμικός

Utopian Feasts and Old Comedy in Crates the Comic Poet

eul_aid: dac

Period: *Κλασική* [Classical](#)
Dialect: *Κωμωδία Ἀττική* [Attic Comedy](#)
Domain: *Κωμωδία* [Comedy](#)
Format: *Ἑμμετρος* [Verse](#)

Crates was an Athenian comic playwright active in the 5th century BCE during the period of Old Comedy. Ancient sources indicate he began his career as an actor in the plays of Cratinus before writing his own comedies. He won his first victory at the City Dionysia festival, likely in the 450s BCE, and was a slightly older contemporary of Aristophanes.

He is historically significant for a key innovation noted by ancient critics. According to Aristotle, Crates was the first Athenian comic poet to move away from the "iambic mode," which primarily featured personal insult and satire. Instead, he began crafting comedies with more generalized, plot-driven stories and situational humor. This shift is seen by scholars as an important step in the evolution of comic theater, paving the way for more structured narratives. His style was remembered as more genial and inventive than the harsh satire of some predecessors.

None of Crates's plays survive intact. They are known only through fragments and titles mentioned in later sources. Known play titles include *Animals*, *Neighbors*, *Lamia*, and *Samians*. While the exact number is uncertain, ancient records attribute between four and eight comedies to him.

Works (4)

- *Ἀποσπάσματα* · [Animated Feast](#) · 93 passages
- *Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Εὐδαίμονος Δείπνου* · [Fragments of a Utopian Feast](#) · 63 passages
- *Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Ἑρατοσθένους* · [Fragments on Eratosthenes](#) · 2 passages
- *Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Ἔρωτος καὶ Εὐσχημοσύνης* · [Fragments on Love and Decorum](#) · 7 passages